



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

*ṛṣayaḥ saṃyata.ātmānaḥ phala.mūla.anila.aśanāḥ | 11.236a[235Ma]
tapasā-eva prapaśyanti trailokyaṃ sa.carācaram || 236 || 11.236c[235Mc]
auśadhāny agado vidyā daivī ca vividhā sthitiḥ | 11.237a[236Ma]
tapasā-eva prasidhyanti tapas teṣāṃ hi sādhanam || 237 || 11.237c[236Mc]*

— Manusmṛti, 11.1.13.3. Four Means of Expiation (Chapter 3), Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

These verses from the Manusmṛti illuminate the profound power of tapas, often translated as austerity, but more accurately understood as disciplined spiritual practice. The verses begin by describing the Rishis, the ancient seers, as individuals who have mastered their inner selves, subsisting on the simple sustenance of fruits, roots, and air. Through their tapas, their dedicated practice and focused intention, they gain the ability to perceive the entirety of the three worlds, encompassing all that moves and does not move. They see the interconnectedness of all things.

The verses then extend this concept, revealing that herbs (medicines), freedom from disease, knowledge, and even the diverse conditions of divine grace are all attained through tapas. Tapas, therefore, is not merely self-denial, but a potent instrument for achieving holistic well-being and profound understanding. It is the means, the sādhanam, by which these blessings manifest. The text underscores that focused spiritual endeavor unlocks not only inner peace and wisdom, but also the capacity to heal, learn, and experience divine favor.

In modern life, where distractions abound and instant gratification is often prioritized, the wisdom of these verses is particularly relevant. Tapas doesn't necessarily mean retreating to a forest and living on roots. It can be integrated into your daily life through practices like mindful meditation, dedicated study, selfless service, or even simply committing to a regular exercise routine. The key is consistent effort, focused intention, and a willingness to cultivate inner discipline. By embracing tapas in its various forms, you can unlock your own potential for healing, growth, and spiritual insight. You too can perceive the interconnectedness of life and navigate the world with greater clarity and compassion.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Where in your life can you introduce a small, disciplined practice that, with consistent effort, could unlock deeper understanding and well-being?